

The Hero of Changing Times

The story of brand 'Hero', a veritable household name across the industry segment that it straddles today, is nothing short of a saga. It is what the folklore is made of. Yes, we are talking about Hero Cycles, that started with manufacturing 25 cycles a day in Ludhiana, to what's known today as the Hero Cycles having a turn-over of approx. Rs.1300 crore. There would be many a reasons that would have contributed to this spectacular growth, but the one that runs at the top is the will and the vision of its founders – the Munjal Brothers, amongst the best known business families in India.

BEGINNING OF A SUCCESS STORY

Back in 1956, a company was born in Ludhiana, and little did the nation knew then, that it was the beginning of the golden era, a revolution that would bring to the fore, India's most economic mode of transportation. From a small company which started with manufacturing 25 cycles a day today's world's largest producer of bicycles.

There would be many a reason that would have contributed to this spectacular growth, but the one that runs at the top is the will and determination of its founders – The Munjal Brothers. Ludhiana based businessmen who have known the Munjal since their early days say that in spite of their modest beginning, it was clear that they were destined for greatness. Compare the 16, 500 cycles that Hero produces a day today to the 25 in 1956 and you can understand what they mean. The remarkable tenacity and hard work shown by the founders translated into sizeable achievements as they built a versatile team of highly skilled engineers, technocrats, administrators, and entrepreneurs.

MEN BEHIND THE BRAND

Few but apt words to define the men behind Hero Cycles. The Late Shri Dayanand (Founder), Brij Mohan Lall



O.P. Munjal, Co-Chairman and CEO, Hero Cycles

(Chairman) the visionary who thought big and worked on developing Hero into a global brand, soft-spoken elder brother Satyanand (Co-Chairman) who zealously handled operations and the youngest, Om Prakash (Co-Chairman and CEO), the man who over the years has led Hero Cycles from the front, the man behind the record-breaking numbers, and who built networks and relationships across the country. Although different from each other, together the Munjals changed the contours of their arena, and altered the way nation looks at biking. Says OP Munjal, "Success depends on the ability to

do better than good-enough. One ought to shed the fear of the unknown and have the confidence to take risks, to experiment, to think and act differently, and have belief in oneself."

And his belief it turns out was right indeed, at a time when cycles meant black cycles only, Hero foresaw that varied tastes from across the society meant varied needs. Subsequently, the company introduced new models and changed the existing perception about cycles. The 'Ranger', India's first All-terrain-bike became an instant and a raging success. Later, Hero's another pioneering effort in ladies segment culminated into the launch of Hero Miss India and the Hero Queen. The bikes that became synonymous of youth among girls.

The innovations kept following one after another with the first International city Bike, Hero Neon and the first

